

KEY FIGURE

SIR FRANCIS DRAKE
1540–96

The English privateer Francis Drake ravaged Spanish colonies and shipping in the Caribbean and Pacific in the 1570s. His daring raid on Cadiz, in 1587, was said to have “sing[ed] the king of Spain’s beard”. Drake was made vice-admiral of the English fleet that would resist the Armada.



▲ Drake was knighted in 1580, as the first Englishman to sail around the world.

► THE SPANISH ARMADA

Phillip II of Spain’s “Invincible Armada”, which was sent to facilitate a cross-Channel invasion of England, is engaged by English galleons firing cannon at the Battle of Gravelines, in August 1588.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

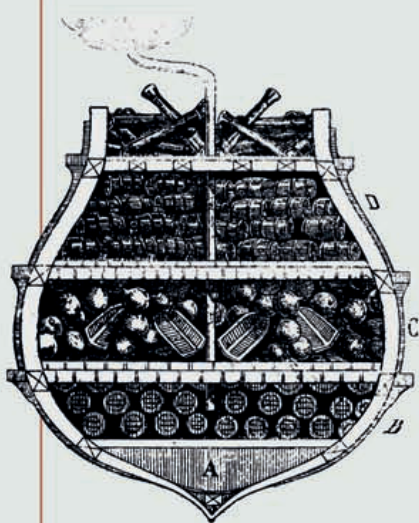
EUROPEAN NAVAL WARFARE

European sailors established oceanic sea routes linking Europe to Asia and the Americas from the late 15th century. The rise of ocean-going sailing ships ushered in a new era of naval warfare, while oared galleys fought for dominance of the Mediterranean.

Galley warfare peaked in the 16th century, as the Turkish Ottoman Empire, aided by privateers, sought control of the Mediterranean. Muslim galleys raided the coast of Italy and landed armies on Christian-held islands, such as Rhodes, Malta, and Cyprus. Christian states responded by deploying large galleys rowed by prisoners using the clumsy but powerful “scalaccio” (echelon) system, with five to seven men on each massive oar. Cannon were mounted on the galleys, and

the soldiers on board also carried firearms. This firepower was no guarantor of success, however: although a Christian alliance won a major naval victory at Lepanto, in 1571, the Muslims largely had the upper hand at sea.

Galleys tended to dominate the Mediterranean at the end of the 17th century, while sailing ships were traditionally considered of little use in combat: dependence on the wind left them outflanked by nimbler, oared vessels. However,



▲ FRENCH FIRESHIP

A ship was packed with combustible material, then set alight and steered towards enemy vessels.